

Q. You represent the people, don't you?

A. I am no Nostradamus. I cannot predict events.

Q. The judiciary has been very active in Pakistan.

A. Yes. Under the restored chief justice. We have great satisfaction that there is a check from the Supreme Court in disputed matters. But there are disputes over everything.

Q. Are you going to be a future prime minister or prisoner?

A. There are questions that don't have answers. Will elections be held? Will they be free and fair? Will opposition parties get together?

Q. The only permanent answer is that Musharraf will stay.

A. That is also uncertain. The question is if Musharraf is eligible to contest another term in office. According to the Constitution, as a former army chief, there's a two-year bar on a government servant to contest. So this issue will end up in courts.

Q. So you are saying Musharraf should give up the uniform, the ban on twice-elected prime ministers contesting elections should be lifted and ...

A. It is important that all corruption cases against party workers be lifted and immunity be given to them. This is in everyone's interest.

Q. Do you support Sharif's deportation?

A. The courts have to rule in this matter. Every citizen has the right to come back. But the other argument is that Sharif traded his rights to live in Pakistan for the dropping of charges against him.

Q. Is your fight against Sharif or Musharraf?

A. My fight is for democracy.

Q. But he has scored a symbolic victory over you.

A. I don't buy it. Very few people were present at the airport when he arrived. He made a mistake by making a deal, involving foreign parties and so on. But people can review mistakes. And I hope he will.

Q. People say America is playing the intermediary between you and Musharraf.

A. They are going back and forth in Pakistan in the larger interest of the war against terrorism.

Q. Are you not talking to them? Aren't you the US nominee for the prime ministership of Pakistan?

A. Of course, we have been talking to them. They talk to all parties. This is the nature of political discourse. We welcome their democratic support.

Q. But unlike you, Sharif is clear that he will not talk to a dictator.

A. I disagree, because he did talk.

Q. That was earlier.

A. We are told that he talked. He was supposed to be travelling on Gulf Air earlier, but he went on a state PIA plane later.

Q. Are you saying he had a secret deal with the Government?

A. I don't know.

Musharraf. The hardliners who formed the Mujahideen and became members of the Taliban and Al-Qaeda do not want the people to get back their rights because their agenda will be rolled back.

Q. So for you, restoration of democracy is more important than whether Musharraf stays in power or not.

A. No. For me, the right of the people to choose their leaders is most important.

Q. And is it none of your business whether Musharraf is chosen or not?

A. The question is whether he is eligible or not.

Q. You are also not eligible to become prime minister under the current laws.

"INDIA CAN MAKE A NUCLEAR SCIENTIST THE PRESIDENT. IN PAKISTAN IT WILL RESULT IN CHAOS."

"IN PAKISTAN WE MAKE RULES BUT THE ARMY DOES NOT ALLOW THESE TO BE IMPLEMENTED."



Q. Will you become prime minister under Musharraf as President?

A. This will depend on the people of Pakistan if they get to vote in free and fair elections.

Q. Assume that the elections are fair.

A. I can't do so because of the ground realities. The point is Pakistan is in turmoil because of so many issues and no one knows the course. Things could lead to an emergency, a military rule and deferment of polls. Even the militant hardliners are frightened of democracy. They seem to have adopted a Minus 3 Formula now—first it was opposition to me, then Sharif and now me, Sharif and

A. Yes, but I can contest elections and Parliament can change the law.

Q. But you would like to become prime minister.

A. Yes. If people give me the mandate, it will be a great honour.

Q. In the event of your party coming to power, is your candidature for prime ministership certain?

A. Of course, my party has only one candidate.

Q. So your mission to Pakistan is to return as prime minister and restore democracy.

A. I can sit back and ask why should I take the risk? But I believe every Pakistani has the right to live in Pakistan.